LACHLAN JOHN KERMODE

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UPDATED MARCH 2026

APPOINTMENTS

2024– **LIMINAL** – *Lead Software Researcher*
Software for human rights investigations; leads its open source tools initiative.

2018–26 **Forensic Architecture** – *Advanced Software Researcher (2018–21), Research Fellow (2021–26)*
Directed engineering for 20+ investigations; founded the Open Source Software subdomain.

2016–18 **Paideia Institute for Humanistic Study** – *Advisory Board*

EDUCATION

2021–27 **PhD in Modern Culture and Media, Brown University (expected 2027)**
Dissertation "Mathematical Materialism: On Capital and Computer Science", committee:
- Joan Copjec (Modern Culture and Media, chair)
- Suresh Venkatasubramanian (Computer Science)
- Holly Case (History)
- Peter Szendy (Comparative Literature)

2022–25 **ScM in Computer Science, Brown University**
Completed concurrently with PhD as an Open Graduate Education fellow. Systems track with coursework in databases, operating systems, distributed systems and networking. Advised:
- Ugur Cetintemel (Computer Science)

2013–18 **AB in Computer Science, Princeton University**
Undergraduate thesis "Towards critical computing: a template for animated documentary", advised:
- Arvind Narayanan (Computer Science)

FELLOWSHIPS

2027 **Remarque Institute, NYU** – *Predoctoral Fellow in Technopolitics and European Democracy*
Spring semester fellowship in New York City. Project title: *From Capital to Calculus: Critical Theory and the Cradle of Computer Science.*

2026 **Bibliotheca Hertziana, Max Planck Institute for Art History** – *Predoctoral Fellow*
Fall semester fellowship with the Machine Visual Culture group in Rome, Italy.

2022–26 **Brown University** – *Open Graduate Education Fellow*
Awarded in 2022 to complete an ScM in Computer Science concurrently with the PhD.

2024 **Institute for Human Sciences** – *Digital Humanism Junior Fellow*
3-month fellowship in Vienna. Project title: *Computer Science, Cybernetics and the Philosophy of Error: The Humanist Critique of Capitalism in an Age of Artificial Intelligence.*

2019–20 **Department of Architecture, University of Auckland** – *Visiting Research Fellow*
Hosted by Karamia Muller.

2017 **Princeton PIIRS** – *Undergraduate Research Fellow*

2015–16 **Paideia Institute** – *Digital Humanities Fellow*

PROCEEDINGS

2026 "Document Infrastructure for Augmented Reading."
CHI (2026). (Lachlan Kermode and Will Crichton.)

2022 "Detecting Tear Gas Canisters With Limited Training Data."
Proceedings of the IEEE/CVF Winter Conference on Applications of Computer Vision (2022): 3674–3682. (Ashwin D'Cruz, Christopher Tegho, Sean Greaves, and Lachlan Kermode.)

2019 "Objects of Violence: Synthetic Data for Practical ML in Human Rights Investigations."
NeurIPS 2019 Joint Workshop on AI for Social Good (2019). (Lachlan Kermode, Jan Freyberg, Alican Akturk, Robert Trafford, Denis Kochetkov, Rafael Pardinas, Eyal Weizman, and Julien Cornebise.)

OTHER PUBLICATIONS

2026– *Weeknotes*
Blog (2026–). weeknotes.ohrg.org.

2018– *One Long Token Soup*
Blog (2018–). ohrg.org.

2024 "Is It Stupid To Think Information Wants To Be Free?"
IWM Post (2024).

2022 "Deconstructing Urbit: The Politics of Software as Infrastructure."
(2022). lachlankermode.com/2022.09.21-deconstructing-urbit.pdf.
— Withdrawn from the *Routledge Handbook of Architecture, Urban Space and Politics.*

2020 "Detecting Tear Gas: Vision and Sound."
Forensic Architecture (2020).
— Software research by Ivan Safrin and Lachlan Kermode.

2019 "Computer Vision in Triple Chaser."
Forensic Architecture (2019).
— Software development and research by Lachlan Kermode.

2019 "Using Timemap for Cartographic Platforms."
Forensic Architecture (2019).
— Contributors: Lachlan Kermode (maintainer), Franc Camps-Febrer, Sam Ludford.

SOFTWARE

2025 Rheo – Typesetting and static site engine based on Typst, 200+ GitHub stars.
2019 Mtriage – Framework to orchestrate the download and analysis of media, 100+ GitHub stars.
2018 Timemap – Exploration, monitoring and classification of incidents in time and space, 380+ GitHub stars.

INDUSTRY

2021–22 **Halter** – *Senior Software Engineer*
First machine learning engineer; built a real-time feature store for IoT devices in Apache Flink.

2021–22 **Social Media Analysis Toolkit [SMAT]** – *Volunteer Research Engineer*
Full stack and MLOps engineering for the SMAT platform.

2020–21 **The Syllabus** – *Developer*
Designed and built the Vue frontends for the-syllabus.com and its subscription cabinet.

2019–21 **Merantix** – *Full stack engineer*
Part-time tooling for deep learning workflows across Merantix ventures.

2018–21 **Forensic Architecture** – *Advanced Software Researcher*
Directed engineering for full stack platforms and machine learning workflows.

TEACHING

Instructor, Free Computing Lab (online)
2025–26 *Capital* for Tech Workers (with Erika Bussman, taught 2025 and 2026)

Instructor of Record, Brown University
2024 Capitalism and Computers in the Era of A.I. (MCM 0903E, upper-level undergraduate seminar)
2022–23 Computer Science for Social Change (CSCI 1951I, taught 2022 and 2023)
2022 Socially Responsible Computing (1-week intensive for new undergraduate TAs)

Teaching Assistant, Brown University
2023 Database Management Systems (CSCI 1270)
2022–23 Theories of Modern Culture and Media (MCM 0150, Head Teaching Assistant)
2022 Digital Media (MCM 0230)

HONORS AND AWARDS

2027 Predoctoral Fellow in Technopolitics and European Democracy – Remarque Institute, NYU.
2026 Predoctoral Fellow – Bibliotheca Hertziana, Max Planck Institute for Art History.
2022–26 Open Graduate Education Fellow – Brown University.
2025 GCB / Narragansett Travel Grant – Grad Center Bar / Narragansett Brewery.
2022–25 Joukowsky Summer Research Award (awarded 2 times) – Brown University.
International Travel Fund Award (awarded 3 times) – Brown University.
Forbes Fund Travel Award (awarded 5 times) – Brown University.
Graduate School Travel Award (awarded 3 times) – Brown University.
2024 Digital Humanism Junior Fellow – Institute for Human Sciences.
2019–20 Visiting Research Fellow – Department of Architecture, University of Auckland.
2018 Top 5 (of 125+) 'Hive' – HackZurich 2018.
2017 Undergraduate Research Fellow – Princeton PIIRS.
2017 Top 25 (of 125+) 'Midnight Grain to Georgia' – HackZurich 2017.
2015–16 Digital Humanities Fellow – Paideia Institute.
2015 1st Place 'ClaireCutApp' – Burda Hackday, Munich.
2015 Dropbox API Prize 'Stitch' – HackZurich 2015.
2015 1st Place 'Pocketbadge' – Bic Lazio Talenttime Hackathon, Rome.
2012 Ian Turner Cup for Best All Rounder – Auckland Grammar School.
2012 H.O Ingram Prize for Senior Latin – Auckland Grammar School.
2012 1st Place – Auckland University Latin Speaking Competition.

INVITED TALKS

2026 "Mathematical Materialism and the Critique of Computer Science."
University of Basel, Basel, Switzerland (2026).

2026 "Commodity."
ZRC SAZU, Ljubljana, Slovenia (2026).

2024 "Capital and the Computer."
Digital Humanism Salon, TU Wien, Vienna, Austria (2024).

2023 "The Automatic Subject."
American Academy in Berlin, Berlin, Germany (2023).

2022 "3-D in Public."
Toronto Geometry Colloquium, Online (2022).

2021 "Slow Boil 'relations' Seminar."
Artspace Aotearoa, Auckland, New Zealand (2021).

2021 "Augmented Authorship."
Lucerne University of Applied Sciences and Arts, Lucerne, Switzerland (2021).

2020 "Deep Learning Intro."
Neural Media: A Cultural History of Machine Learning, Brown University, Providence, RI (2020).

2019 "AI and Human Rights."
Sigrid Rausing Trust, London, United Kingdom (2019).

2019 "Citizen Forensics Workshop."
School of Machines, Berlin, Germany (2019).

2019 "Spatial Research Practice Roundtable."
Flaneur Festival, Haus der Kulturen der Welt, Berlin, Germany (2019).

2019 "Machine Learning in Forensic Investigations."
United Nations / Alan Turing Institute Conference, Alan Turing Institute, London (2019).

2019 "Machine Learning and Synthetic Data."
Goldsmiths, University of London, London, United Kingdom (2019).

2019 "Programming for Open-Source Architects."
Architectural Association, London, United Kingdom (2019).

2019 "On Algorithmic Vision."
London Critical Theory Summer School, Birkbeck, London, United Kingdom (2019).

2019 "Computer Visions."
Princeton-Weimar Summer School for Media Studies, Weimar, Germany (2019).

2019 "Using Synthetic Data."
Element AI, London (2019).

2018 "Machine Learning in Counter Forensics."
Princeton University, Princeton, NJ (2018).

2018 "Lessons in Counter Forensics: Interpretation."
Turner Prize Seminars, Tate Britain, London, United Kingdom (2018).

PRESENTATIONS

2026 "The Source and Its Bugs: The Cosmos of Illiterate Programming."
History and Philosophy of Programming, Basel, Switzerland (2026).

2026 "Capital, Calculus, and the Computer: On Marx's Mathematical Materialism."
Historical Materialism Annual Conference, London, United Kingdom (2026).

2026 "The Strange Nature of Interpretability."
Seeing Machines: Aesthetics, Education and Semiotics of AI Images, Unimore, Reggio Emilia, Italy (2026).

2025 "The Machine That Therefore I Am."
Historical Materialism Twenty-Second Annual Conference, London, United Kingdom (2025).

2025 "Value Is an Automatic Subject."
University of Dundee Student Colloquium, Dundee, United Kingdom (2025).

2025 "Is There a Theory of the Subject in Marx?"
LACK V, Columbus, Ohio (2025).

2024 "Love's First Site."
IWM Spring Fellows Conference, Vienna, Austria (2024).

2023 "Men Dressed as Ghosts."
Modern Culture and Media Graduate Colloquium, Brown University, Providence, RI (2023).

2022 "Political Economies of the Cloud."
GRiSTS 2022, Cambridge, MA, USA (2022).

INVESTIGATIONS / EXHIBITIONS

2024 **Centiquatre Paris** – *From Sea to Sky*
In partnership with LIMINAL, exposes the aggressive methods of surveillance operations in the Mediterranean where more than 40,000 migrants have lost their lives at sea. Contributed to the design and development of a physical installation contextualizing redacted information from Frontex, the European Border and Coast Guard Agency. Select reviews:
- Fisheye Immersive

2023–24 **Harvard Collection of Scientific Instruments** – *Surveillance: From Vision to Data*
Considers surveillance beyond the realm of cameras and their watchers, exposing the profound influence of data. Contributed an original video on loop that introduced mtriage, a software I developed to scrape public domain data.

2023 **Inferstudio** – *Antarctic Resolution*
Interactive platform developed in partnership with Inferstudio.

2021–22 **Tauranga Art Gallery** – *The Moral Drift*
In collaboration with Fraser Crichton and Malcolm Richards, this exhibition offers a partial history of Aotearoa's state care system, uncovering a legacy of abuse and the resiliency of the survivors who continue to seek justice today.

2021 **Artspace Aotearoa** – *Slow Boil*
In collaboration with kaupapa Māori community group and kai security advocates Boil Up Crew, as well as a group of contributing practitioners spanning architecture, community advocacy, design, food sovereignty, software and the visual arts. Explored the relationship between the mahi ngā-kai/kai rituals, and tā wahi/notions of space, mana motuhake/sovereignty, and mapping. Works were collectively produced and installed over the course of the exhibition, alongside existing investigative works by Forensic Architecture. Select reviews:
- Architecture Now
- e-flux

2020–21 **ZKM | Karlsruhe** – *Critical Zones: Observations for Earthly Politics*
Dedicated to the critical situation of this fragile membrane of life. Contributed with a project on the toxic clouds that are mobilised by state and corporate powers such as tear gas, herbicide and chlorine bombs.

2020 **Forensic Architecture** – *Brutality at BLM Protests*
Investigative timemap deployment documenting instances of police brutality throughout the 2020 protests.

2020 **Adam Art Gallery** – *Violent Legalities*
Cartographically chronologises three separate projects, each aiming to spatialise relationships between legislative activity and occurrences of violence to inspect enduring trends between settler-colonial law-making processes and state policies in Aotearoa/New Zealand. Nominated to be showcased in the 2020 Ars Electronica showcase in Aotearoa New Zealand. Select reviews:
- Scoop News
- Architecture Now

2020 **De Young Museum** – *Model Zoo* in *Uncanny Valley: Being human in the age of AI*
Presented the research in computer vision and synthetic data from my work in investigations at Forensic Architecture. Accompanying technical details are available at forensic-architecture.org/investigation/detecting-tear-gas. Select reviews:
- Frieze
- Artfix Daily

2019 **Forensic Architecture** – *The Battle of Ilovaisk*
Investigative timemap deployment documenting Russian military presence in Eastern Ukraine in 2014.

2019 **Whitney Museum of American Art** – *Triple Chaser in Whitney Biennial 2019*
Forensic Architecture's invited contribution with filmmaker Laura Poitras and Praxis Films presenting machine learning research I conducted in Forensic Architecture investigations. Accompanying technical details are available at forensic-architecture.org/investigation/cv-in-triple-chaser. Select reviews:
- T.J. Demos in e-flux.
- New Yorker.
- Hyperallergic.
- Nicholas Gamso

2019 **Fridman Gallery** – *Talking Popcorn's First Last Words with Nina Katchadourian*
I was one of sixteen people interviewed from a wide variety of fields and areas of expertise, asked to address Talking Popcorn's last words from a particular disciplinary perspective. The soundtrack played in a room with the burned, damaged carcass of the first machine standing on a black plinth upon which was written the machine's final pronouncement.

2018 **Tate Britain** – *The Long Duration of a Split Second in Turner Prize nomination 2018*
An exhibition produced for Forensic Architecture's nomination for the 2018 Turner Prize Developed an interactive platform displaying more than 30Gb of point clouds and other citizen-mapped data in the Negev/Naqab desert. Select reviews:
- Haaretz
- The Times
- The Guardian
- The New York Times

2018 **Forensic Architecture** – *Triple Chaser*
Investigative mtriage deployment documenting tear gas use by Safariland, a company associated with ex-Whitney board member Warren B. Kanders.

RESEARCH ASSISTANTSHIPS

Research Assistant, Brown University

2024 Research for Lindsay Caplan (Art History)
2023 Auto-scaling in Apache Flink and Kubernetes with reinforcement learning, advised by Ugur Cetintemel (Computer Science)
2022 Ethics curriculum for the undergraduate Computer Science program, with Julia Netter (Philosophy)

ADVISING

Graduate Advisor, Socially Responsible Computing Program, Brown University

2021–23 Lena Cohen, SRC Teaching Assistant (now at the Electronic Frontier Foundation)
2021–23 Erika Bussman, SRC Teaching Assistant (now at Google)

Mentor, Auckland University of Technology

2026 Sophia Lawler, graduated 2026 (now at LIMINAL)

READING AND WORKING GROUPS

2026– **(Organizer)** The Language of Language Machines – Working group co-run with Ryan Healey, affiliated with the Digital Theory Lab.
2025– Digital Theory Lab, NYU – regular participant.
2024– **(Organizer)** Maths, Philosophy and History reading group – Cogut Institute.
Bi-weekly online. Past guests include Imogen Forbes-Macphail and Leif Weatherby.
2025 PLISS summer school – with Jan Vitek, Shriram Krishnamurthi, Ben Titzer et al.

2024–25 AI, Decoloniality and Creative Poetry Translation – Technical advisor, Oxford University. Research using AI tools for low-resource and poetic translation run by Matthew Reynolds.
2024–25 RISD Center for Complexity, *Systems thinking from the margins* – with Jon Soske, Tim Maly et al.
2022–24 AI faculty reading group – with Eli Upfal, Lindsay Caplan et al.
2023 BICAR Summer Intensive, 4-week intensive – with Rohit Goel et al.
2022 *Simultaneity* Sommerfrische, 1-week retreat in Poland – with Holly Case et al.
2021–22 **(Organizer)** A.R.G.@Brown Reading Group – Department of Computer Science, Brown University.
2018–21 **(Organizer)** A.R.G. London Reading Group – Goldsmiths, University of London.

SERVICE

2026 Evaluator – PhD program applications, Max Planck Artificial Intelligence Network (MP-AIX).
2026 Conference co-organizer – *Cloud: From Paris to Tehran.* Celebrating Joan Copjec's 2025 book.
2026 Conference co-organizer – *The geopolitics of software at scale*, Cogut Humanities Lab. 6 faculty invited from the U.S. and Canada for 2 days of discussion.
2025 Program committee – Information+, a conference for information design and visualization.
2023 Ambassador – Women in Data Science (WiDS), Brown University.
2023 Conference co-organizer – Modern Culture and Media Graduate Colloquium.
2022–23 Department representative – GSC representative for Modern Culture and Media.
2022–23 Graduate Representative – Committee for the SRC program expansion, Brown University.
2022 Organizer – Critical Computing Speaker Series, Modern Culture and Media / Computer Science.

PRESS

2024 "Cycling Typing."
One Long Token Soup (2024).
— Front page of Hacker News (#8).

2021 "Software Reconnaissance: An Interview with Lachlan Kermode."
The College Hill Independent (2021). (Lucas Gelfond.)

2020 "Forensic Architecture: An Interview with Lachlan Kermode."
Interstices: Journal of Architecture and Related Arts 20 (2020): 128–135. 10.24135/ijara.vi.654. (Anthony Brand.)

2020 "Signs of Use and Past Presences."
Architecture Now (2020). (Anthony Brand.)
— Quotes Kermode on Forensic Architecture.

CITED IN

2021 *Investigative Aesthetics: Conflicts and Commons in the Politics of Truth*
Verso (2021). (Matthew Fuller and Eyal Weizman.)
— Credits Kermode with developing the "practice and theory of open-source software research" at Forensic Architecture.

LANGUAGES

English (native), Italian (proficient), Latin (reading), German (reading).